A Guide to Navigating Employment and Disability Data

Jean Winsor, PhD
Suzzanne Freeze, MA
Alberto Migliore, PhD

State Employment Leadership Network

NASDDDS
National Association of State Directors of Developmental Disabilities Services

ICI ThinkWork!
INSTITUTE FOR COMMUNITY INCLUSION, UMASS BOSTON

A Guide to Navigating Employment and Disability Data

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Introduction

Policy shifts over the past several decades have created an agenda that calls for a sustained commitment to integrated employment for individuals with disabilities. Despite these clear intentions, unemployment and underemployment of individuals with disabilities continues to be a major public policy issue.

For people with intellectual and developmental disabilities (IDD), the disparity in labor market participation grows. Data suggest only 17% of individuals who receive supports from state IDD agencies work in either individual or group integrated employment (Human Services Research Institute, 2025), and 23% of individuals who receive day services from a state IDD agency participate in a service designed to support integrated employment (Winsor et al., 2025). At the same time, participation in non-work services has grown steadily, suggesting that employment services continue to be viewed as an add-on service rather than a systemic change (Mank et al., 2003; Winsor et al., 2025).

Data on the state of employment for individuals with disabilities (as briefly synthesized above) is available through myriad of data collection systems. A growing emphasis on government accountability at the state and federal levels has increased interest in the collection and use of data on employment outcomes.

However, many disability data systems are only loosely coordinated across various agencies, and many state service systems have fragmented and incomplete data systems in place. Stapleton & Thornton (2009, p.4) note that “although the challenges to improving the data are substantial, they pale in comparison to the likely consequences of failing to do so, both for people with disabilities and for taxpayers.”

This toolkit is designed to provide guidance on how to use currently available national and state-level aggregate datasets to weave together a picture of the employment outcomes of adults with IDD. Datasets are grouped by the type of data they report: agency-level data, and general employment trend data. This toolkit is based upon the Partnerships In Employment Toolkit originally developed by Winsor and Migliore.

Agency-Level Data

- National Survey of State Intellectual and Developmental Disabilities Agencies
- National Core Indicators
- Rehabilitation Services Administration (RSA-911)
- State Performance Indicators: 13 and 14
- Transition and Postsecondary Programs for Students with Intellectual Disabilities (TPSID)

General Employment Trend Data

- American Community Survey (ACS)
- Current Population Survey (CPS)

The datasets will be described under the following headings:

- Description of the dataset
- How to access the data
- How to use the data

The final section of the toolkit will offer suggestions on how to use the available datasets to create a picture of the employment landscape in your state for people with IDD.

Agency-Level Data

A. National Survey of State Intellectual and Developmental Disabilities Agencies

DESCRIPTION OF THE NATIONAL SURVEY OF STATE INTELLECTUAL AND DEVELOPMENTAL DISABILITIES AGENCIES DATASET

This survey is part of a longitudinal study commissioned by the Administration on Community Living to analyze employment and day service trends beginning in FY1988 for individuals with intellectual and developmental disabilities (IDD) and closely related conditions. Between 1988 and 2004, the survey was administered on a semi-annual basis; however, starting in 2007, information has been collected annually.

This survey collects summary data on employment and service distribution and funding at the state level annually. Table 1 provides a description of service definitions. Individuals may be counted in more than one service category at a time, so percentages within the report may add up to more than 100%.

The survey collects data on participation by service, which means it does not directly assess participation in employment. In general, participation in integrated employment services does not necessarily mean an individual is employed. Individuals who receive an integrated employment service include those who are receiving services with an immediate goal of entering employment, such as job development, and those receiving long-term services to support maintaining employment. It also only includes individuals who receive services from a state IDD agency.

Table 1. IDD Survey Service Definitions

Type of Service/ Setting	Work	Non-Work
Community	**Integrated employment:** Integrated employment services are provided in a community setting and support or lead directly to the participant's paid employment. Specifically, integrated employment includes services that support entering or maintaining competitive employment, individual supported employment, group supported employment, and self-employment.	**Community-based non-work:** Community-based non-work includes all services that are focused on supporting people with disabilities to access community activities in settings where most people do not have disabilities. It does not include paid employment.
Facility	**Facility-based work:** Facility-based work includes employment in a facility where most people have disabilities, with continuous job-related supports and supervision. This includes sheltered employment, work activity centers, or extended employment programs.	**Facility-based non-work:** Facility-based non-work are programs where the primary focus is skill training, activities of daily living, recreation, and/or professional therapies in a facility where most people have disabilities. This typically includes day activity and day habilitation services. These services do not involve paid employment.

HOW TO ACCESS THE DATA

Users can generate tables and charts of key variables using an interactive chart builder at ICI's ThinkWork StateData . This website also allows users to download the annual report StateData: The National Report on Employment Services and Outcomes in PDF format, or to download raw data of selected variables. Select "Build a chart", then "State IDD Agencies" database.

HOW TO USE THE DATA

The survey is designed to provide information on a state's investment in integrated employment and other services. Data include:

- trends in the number of people served in integrated employment, facility-based employment, and facility-based and community-based non-work programs
- trends in the number of people working in integrated jobs
- funding sources that are being used to support employment and day services
- the allocation of funds across day and employment services

This data can be used to understand changes in state investment in integrated employment and other services, as well as to compare states' service outcomes.

The survey is not designed to collect data on specific age groups or geographic locations within a given state. Additionally, the data cannot be used to track the outcomes of specific individuals.

B. National Core Indicators

DESCRIPTION OF THE NATIONAL CORE INDICATORS DATASET

The National Core Indicators project (NCI) is a voluntary effort of participating state IDD agencies to monitor and track their performance. The core indicators are standard measures used across states to assess the outcomes of services provided to individuals and families.

Indicators address key areas of concern, including employment, rights, service planning, community inclusion, choice, and health and safety.

NCI collects data at the individual level on a randomly selected sample of individuals who receive supports from participating states. NCI includes approximately 100 consumer, family, system, and health and safety outcomes. The information is gathered through three main data sources: (1) the In-person Survey, (2) three Family Surveys, and (3) a Staff Stability Survey (e.g., staff turnover). The NCI is continuously evolving, with its measures periodically revised—added, removed, or updated—to align with the changing priorities of participating states (National Core Indicator, 2022).

During the 2021–22 data collection cycle, 48 states, the District of Columbia, and 21 sub-state entities participated in NCI, yielding 13,559 valid in-person surveys completed. (National Core Indicators, 2022).

NCI examines five groups of quality indicators with subdomains:

- Individual outcomes: employment, community inclusion, community participation, choice and decision-making, relationships, and satisfaction
- System performance: Self-direction, service coordination, workforce, and access
- Health, welfare, and rights: safety, health, medications, wellness, and respect/rights
- Staff stability and competence
- Family experience: information and planning, access and support delivery, workforce, choice and decision making, community connections, health/welfare/safety, and family satisfaction

The **In-Person Survey (IPS)** is an interview-based survey of individuals who are 18 years of age or older and receiving at least one paid service from the state (in addition to case management). For some questions, individuals are able to choose more than one response. The NCI surveys have been tested for validity and reliability.

NCI-IPS operates on a 6-year revisions cycle to regularly ensure the current set of indicators meet the needs of state systems and reflect current needs in the field. Survey changes are guided by state managers, people with disabilities, and other experts in the field. The 2023–24 survey tool reflected changes based on this guidance and additional survey testing. Please note, any changes to the survey tool may affect comparison to previous years' data, therefore any cross-year comparison should be made with caution.

Examples of data available include the following:

- Percentage of people who are reported to have competitive paid jobs in community-based businesses
- Type of paid community job
- Average number of bi-weekly hours by type of paid community job
- Average hourly wages by type of community job
- Percentage of people who are reported to have a goal of community employment in their individualized service plan
- Among those who are not reported to have a paid job in the community: percentage who want a paid job in the community
- Percentage of people who do the things they like in their communities as much as they want
- Of those with a paid community job: percentage of people who report having input in choosing their paid community job
- Percentage of people reported to have a paid community job who report that they are satisfied with their job

For more information, explore the NCI In-Person Survey 2023-24 National Report.

HOW TO ACCESS THE DATA

Users can download reports on states that participate in NCI and on specific indicators: Survey Reports & Insights - NCI-IDD

HOW TO USE THE DATA

The purpose of the program, which began in 1997, is to support National Association of State Directors of Developmental Disabilities Services member agencies to gather a standard set of performance and outcome measures. States can use these measures to track their own performance over time, to compare results across states, and to establish national benchmarks.

What types of information are states able to learn based upon these questions?

- The number and percentage of people sampled working in the community
- The number and percentage of people sampled in each type of community job
- The number of people who want a job but do not have one
- The number of people who want to work and have this goal in their Individual Service Plan
- The industries that individuals are concentrated in
- How many hours on average people are working
- How much money on average people earn
- Whether people use special technology to do their job
- Whether people take part in classes, training, or skill building activities to gain skills and expand their job opportunities

NCI specifically cautions that while it is a “tool for understanding programmatic, policy, and practice issues at the systems level, it is not meant to understand the circumstances of a particular person or family” (National Core Indicators, 2017, p. 14). NCI also states that the data should not be used to evaluate the performance of providers or regions of the state, or as a single point of data for Center for Medicare and Medicaid Services evidence packages.

C. Rehabilitation Services Administration (RSA-911)

DESCRIPTION OF RSA-911 DATASET

The RSA-911 is an administrative case-reporting database that describes the characteristics, services received, and employment or postsecondary education outcomes of people with any type of disabilities who exit the vocational rehabilitation (VR) program. Nearly 400,000 people with disabilities exit the program every year, about a third of whom exit with paid jobs. The types of disabilities reported in the RSA-911 dataset are those identified by rehabilitation counselors as the causes of either a primary or secondary impairment to employment.

The ICI's criteria for whether an individual is considered to have an intellectual disability (ID) is if code 25 (intellectual disability in the RSA-911 dataset) was reported as the cause of either a primary or secondary substantial impediment to employment. An employment outcome is reported after a person held one of the following closures for at least 90 days: (1) competitive and integrated employment or (2) supported employment.

Key data points that can be examined through the RSA-911 are:

- Number and percentage of people receiving services
- Types of services received
- Number and percentage of people employed at exit from VR services
- Time from referral to employment
- Weekly earnings at exit from VR services
- Weekly hours worked at exit from VR services
- Participation in postsecondary education
- Demographics

HOW TO ACCESS THE DATA

- Users can generate tables and charts of key variables for each state and the nation using an interactive chart builder at ThinkWork StateData. . This website also allows users to download an annual report titled StateData: The National Report on Employment Services and Outcomes in PDF format, or to download raw data of selected variables.
- The full dataset is available upon request to the Rehabilitation Services Administration (RSA). Data are made available approximately one year after the close of each federal fiscal year, and include individual records, with identifying information removed for each person who exited the VR program. However, as of this writing, the release of the data remains uncertain due to ongoing federal workforce policy changes.
- On a state level, data are maintained and managed by the state VR agency.

HOW TO USE THE DATA

The data from the RSA-911 dataset is key for understanding the role of the VR program in supporting people with disabilities in getting employment or postsecondary education. Specifically, these data tell us how many people with disabilities accessed the VR program, what types of services they received, and what outcomes they achieved. This information is available at the state level, allowing comparisons across states. Moreover, data are available for types of disabilities, allowing comparisons across disabilities. Finally, the data can be compared across demographic characteristics of job seekers, including gender, age, race, and education.

Since the data are collected by VR counselors for administrative—not research—purposes, they are not tested scientifically for validity and reliability. For example, the types of disability reported for a person may be influenced by subjective perceptions of the counselor during eligibility determination, types of services reported may vary across VR offices, and earnings might reflect job seekers' resistance to disclosing their full income. Also, the RSA-911 data does not include information about job retention after case closure.

Participation in VR services by people with IDD also reflects the overall emphasis on employment outcomes in the state. The number of individuals exiting VR services will depend on the VR agency's effectiveness in reaching out to and serving this population, but also on the extent to which schools and the state IDD agency make referrals and emphasize employment as a priority. Understanding the reasons for levels of participation or outcomes will require a broader interagency discussion.

D. State Performance Indicators: 13 and 14

DESCRIPTION OF THE STATE PERFORMANCE INDICATORS: 13 AND 14 DATASETS

Under the Individuals with Disabilities Education Act (IDEA), all states are mandated to report on 20 indicators of educational services and outcomes for special education students. Each state submits an annual performance report on these indicators to the Office of Special Education Programs.

Indicator 13 represents the percentage of students with an appropriate transition plan. Indicator 14 represents the percent enrolled in higher education, and/or employed, one year after exiting school. Factors that make up each indicator are described next.

Indicator 13

- "Percent of youth with individualized education plans (IEP) aged 16 and above with an IEP that includes appropriate measurable postsecondary goals that are annually updated and based upon an age- appropriate transition assessment, transition services, including courses of study, that will reasonably allow the student to meet those postsecondary goals, and annual IEP goals related to the student's transition services needs.
- Evidence that the student was invited to the IEP team meeting where transition services are to be discussed and evidence that, if appropriate, a representative of any participating agency was invited to the IEP team meeting with the prior consent of the parent or student who has reached the age of majority." (20 U.S.C. 1416(a)(3)(B))

States used a variety of checklists to measure Indicator 13, including the National Technical Assistance Center on Transition: The Collaborative (NTACT:C) I-13 Checklist or their own checklist. Explore the checklists on the NTACT:C website.

Indicator 14

- "Percent of youth who are no longer in secondary school, had IEPs in effect at the time they left school, and were:
  - a. Enrolled in higher education within one year of leaving high school.
  - b. Enrolled in higher education or competitively employed within one year of leaving high school.
  - c. Enrolled in higher education or in some other postsecondary education or training program; or competitively employed or in some other employment within one year of leaving high school". (20 U.S.C. 1416(a)(3)(B)).

There is considerable state-to-state variation in how these data are collected, including differing definitions of higher education and competitive employment, the use of a census or a representative sample of students, and the data collection method (in-person interview, mailed questionnaire, internet survey, state longitudinal data system, or combination of methods).

HOW TO ACCESS THE DATA

- Find summary data on national performance outcomes for Indicator 13 and 14 [on the NTACT:C website].
- State Annual Performance Reports are available from [the US Department of Education].
- Additional data, including data by district, may be available from a state's department or division of special education.

HOW TO USE THE DATA

Data on Indicator 13 can tell you the percent of assessed students with an appropriate transition plan. The NTACT:C is the national coordinating center for Indicator 13. NTACT:C provides technical assistance and disseminates information related to evidence-based transition practices for students with disabilities, college and career readiness for youth with disabilities, and compliance with Indicator 13.

Data on Indicator 14 can tell you the percent of assessed students within one year after exiting school who are:

a. enrolled in higher education

b. enrolled in higher education or competitively employed

c. enrolled in higher education or in some other postsecondary education or training program, or competitively employed or in some other employment

All states are mandated to report educational outcomes of special education students: graduation and dropout rate (IDEA Part B Indicators 1 and 2), percent served in integrated classrooms (Indicator 5), percent with an appropriate transition plan (Indicator 13), and percent enrolled in higher education and/or employed one year after exiting high school (Indicator 14). However, while these indicator data are available state-by-state for the full population of students with disabilities, they are not consistently reported or available by disability category.

Employment status is embedded in parts b and c of Indicator 14. As a result, Indicator 14 does not provide a specific statistic for the number of individuals who are competitively employed. As of this writing, the data collection and release of the data remains uncertain due to ongoing federal workforce policy changes.

E. Transition and Postsecondary Programs for Students with Intellectual Disabilities (TPSID)

DESCRIPTION OF THE TPSID DATA

The Transition and Postsecondary Programs for Students with Intellectual Disability (TPSID) are cohorts of colleges and universities funded to create, expand, or enhance high-quality, inclusive higher education options that support positive outcomes for students with intellectual disability, including employment. The TPSID model demonstration program was first launched by the Office of Postsecondary Education (OPE) in 2010 through 5-year grants and remains active at the time of writing.

A National Coordinating Center (NCC) was established to evaluate and provide technical assistance to TPSID projects. Think College at the Institute for Community Inclusion, University of Massachusetts Boston, has served as the NCC since 2010. The NCC publishes annual reports of TPSID data, summarizing quantitative information such as enrollment figures, demographics, and program characteristics as well as details about academics, residential options, employment services, financial aid, strategic partnerships, and post-exit outcomes.

HOW TO ACCESS THE DATA

TPSID data are available through the annual reports published on the Think College portal. These reports include tables, charts, and aggregate data for major areas such as enrollment, demographics, coursework, credentials, employment outcomes, housing, and program exit. Executive summaries and one-page highlights are also available on the website.

HOW TO USE THE DATA

The data are intended for descriptive use by researchers, practitioners, policymakers, and program leaders to examine TPSID implementation, monitor progress toward federal requirements, and inform inclusive higher education practices. The NCC uses the data in a data-driven technical assistance model in which NCC technical assistance staff review with each TPSID indicator, such as inclusive course enrollment and employment participation, and identify areas for improvement, such as reducing non-completion rates or increasing access to federal financial aid.

The data also support policy advocacy [e.g., expanding access to Comprehensive Transition and Postsecondary (CTP) programs to increase availability of federal student aid], institutional self-assessment (e.g., alignment with the Think College Standards), and resource development by the NCC. Trend data help institutions compare their outcomes to national benchmarks—such as post-exit employment rates for similar populations—and guide decisions about sustainability, partnerships, and quality improvement.

General Employment Trend Data

A. American Community Survey (ACS)

DESCRIPTION OF ACS DATASET

The American Community Survey (ACS) is a national annual survey that—mirroring the US decennial census—investigates topics such as gender, age, race, disability, employment, income, poverty, veteran status, and other demographic and personal data. Unlike the US census, which colleges data from the entire US population, the ACS collects data from a random sample and focuses on a shorter list of key variables. Because of random selection and by using weighted data, however, the ACS can be generalized to the entire national population, and data are available at the state and county level annually. The US Census Bureau administers the survey.

The ACS reports on several broad disability categories based on individual responses to the survey. The primary variables used to identify presence of a disability include:

- Hearing difficulty (i.e., deaf or having serious difficulty hearing)
- Vision difficulty (i.e., blind or having serious difficulty seeing, even when wearing glasses)
- Cognitive difficulty (i.e., because of a physical, mental, or emotional problem, having difficulty remembering, concentrating, or making decisions)
- Ambulatory difficulty (i.e., having serious difficulty walking or climbing stairs)
- Self-care difficulty (i.e., having difficulty bathing or dressing)
- Independent living difficulty (i.e., because of a physical, mental, or emotional problem, having difficulty doing errands alone, such as visiting a doctor's office or shopping)

HOW TO ACCESS THE DATA

For select variables, users can explore the interactive chart builder available at ThinkWork StateData or download the annual report StateData: The National Report on Employment Services and Outcomes available on that website. The chart builder allows comparisons between people with no disability and individuals with a cognitive, hearing, visual, or physical disability.

The Explore Census Data website is appropriate for guided searches of broader variables and for obtaining general information, including documentation on methodology and instructions for obtaining the raw data for analysis.

HOW TO USE THE DATA

One advantage of the ACS dataset is that it allows comparing characteristics and employment outcomes of people with disabilities with the corresponding information for the general population of people without disabilities. Data are available at the state and county level annually. Therefore, these data provide information that closely mirrors the information available from the decennial US Census without having to wait 10 years for updated results.

The ACS also allows users to explore employment status as it relates to other variables, including poverty, living situation, and occupation and industry. These data are critical for informing local policies.

Because of the broad definition of disability used in the ACS, comparison of findings from this survey with findings from other disability-specific data sources should be made with caution. For example, the ACS identifies a person as having cognitive disabilities when a “yes” response is provided to the following question: “Because of a physical, mental, or emotional condition, does this person have serious difficulty

concentrating, remembering, or making decisions?” This very broad question will include individuals with a wide range of disability experiences and is not directly comparable with individuals with IDD.

Before 2008, the definition of this group category was slightly different, and participants were identified as having a “mental disability”—instead of cognitive disability—if they reported difficulties in learning, remembering, or concentrating because of a physical, mental, or emotional condition lasting six months or more. Due to this change in disability definition, it is challenging to compare disability data from before 2008 with later years.

B. Current Population Survey (CPS)

DESCRIPTION OF CPS DATASET

The Current Population Survey (CPS) is a monthly survey of about 60,000 households with a focus on labor force, employment, unemployment, people not in the labor force, hours of work, earnings, and other demographic and labor force characteristics. Since 2009, the survey has collected employment data about people with disabilities. With the exception of the disability population, data are available both at the national and the state level. The survey is conducted by the Bureau of the Census for the Bureau of Labor Statistics, and is the source of the Employment Situation, the monthly Bureau of Labor Statistics report on national employment statistics.

HOW TO ACCESS THE DATA

- The monthly Employment Situation Summary includes data on individuals with and without disabilities.
- Additional data are available on the Bureau of Labor Statistics CPS webpage.
- To carry out your own data analyses, download the raw data on the US Census CPS Dataset webpage.

HOW TO USE THE DATA

Because the questions about disability status are the same for the CPS and the ACS, the findings of these two surveys are comparable. The CPS data, however, have the advantage of providing the data on a monthly basis. Therefore, the CPS is a better tool for monitoring short-term employment trends.

Due to the smaller sample size of the CPS and the higher frequency of data collection, data from the CPS are less suitable than data from the ACS or the decennial US census for investigating long-term trends.

Moreover, because of the smaller sample size, the disability data are not available at the state level, and the Employment Summary only provides a general statistic for employment across all disabilities. Finally, like the ACS, the definition of disability in the CPS is broad, making it challenging to compare findings from the CPS with findings from other disability-specific data sources.

Suggestions for Using Data

The final section of this toolkit offers suggestions on how to use the available datasets to describe the employment landscape in your state for people with IDD, including transition-age youth. Suggestions include discussion questions for using each dataset as a catalyst for change, and examples of figures and tables that can be used to inform the discussion.

Sample Discussion Questions

It can be useful to frame the presentation of employment data by posing a series of questions to encourage discussion about each of the variables in the dataset. Sample discussion questions include:

- How do my state's employment outcomes compare to the national average?
- What state has the highest/lowest outcomes?
- How do the outcomes of individuals with IDD compare to those without disabilities?
- Are the longitudinal trends showing a decline, increase, or no change in the data?
- How can we use these data in our communication with key partners?
- Are we satisfied with our state's employment outcomes?
- If not, what goals could we set for improvement? What needs to happen from a system perspective to meet the goal?

Sample Tables, Graphs, and Narrative to Describe Data

Graphs and tables are useful methods to present data to help frame the discussion. The ThinkWork StateData website allows users to create on-demand displays of data from many of the datasets discussed in this toolkit. This section of the toolkit also offers sample tables and narrative to describe the data. The following include examples for the RSA-911 dataset, the American Community Survey, the National Survey of State Intellectual and Developmental Disabilities Agencies Day and Employment Services, Social Security Administration data, and the National Core Indicators.

EXAMPLE 1: RSA-911

Table Example

Here is an example of how data from the RSA-911 dataset can be used to compare the employment outcomes of people with ID with the corresponding figures from people with other disabilities in the US, over time. Specifically, Figure 1 shows the total number of closures, the number of closures in employment, the number of closures that involved an individual plan of employment without an employment outcome, the rehabilitation rate, and the percentage of closures with an employment outcome of working-age people with ID and people with other types of disabilities, during the period 2015–2022, nationally.

Figure 1. Example RSA-911 Table: Case Closures and Employment Outcomes

	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022
Total number of closures	546,923	534,470	418,539	476,704	462,108	421,315	342,220	359,612
Total number of closures with ID	47,390	47,595	38,642	44,487	45,110	41,644	33,663	36,789
Closures into an employment setting	183,167	183,455	132,433	150,870	138,910	128,301	104,640	118,326
Closures with ID into an employment setting	18,116	18,383	13,134	16,254	15,873	14,531	11,316	13,654
Closures with an IPE but no employment outcome	140,338	139,726	137,695	162,871	162,901	161,537	144,289	146,379
Closures with ID and an IPE but no employment outcome	14,104	14,861	14,706	17,966	18,876	18,613	16,695	17,371
Rehabilitation rate for all closures with an IPE	57.0%	57.0%	49.0%	48.0%	46.0%	44.0%	42.0%	45.0%
Rehabilitation rate for all closures with ID**	56.0%	55.0%	47.0%	47.0%	46.0%	44.0%	40.0%	44.0%
Percentage of all closures into employment	33.5%	34.3%	31.6%	31.6%	30.1%	30.5%	30.6%	32.9%
Percentage of all closures with ID into employment	38.2%	38.6%	34.0%	36.5%	35.2%	34.9%	33.6%	37.1%

Source: Rehabilitation Services Administration 911 (RSA-911), Winsor et al., 2025, page 7.
*Rehabilitation Rate = (# closures into employment) / (# closures into employment + # closures with an IPE but no employment outcome).

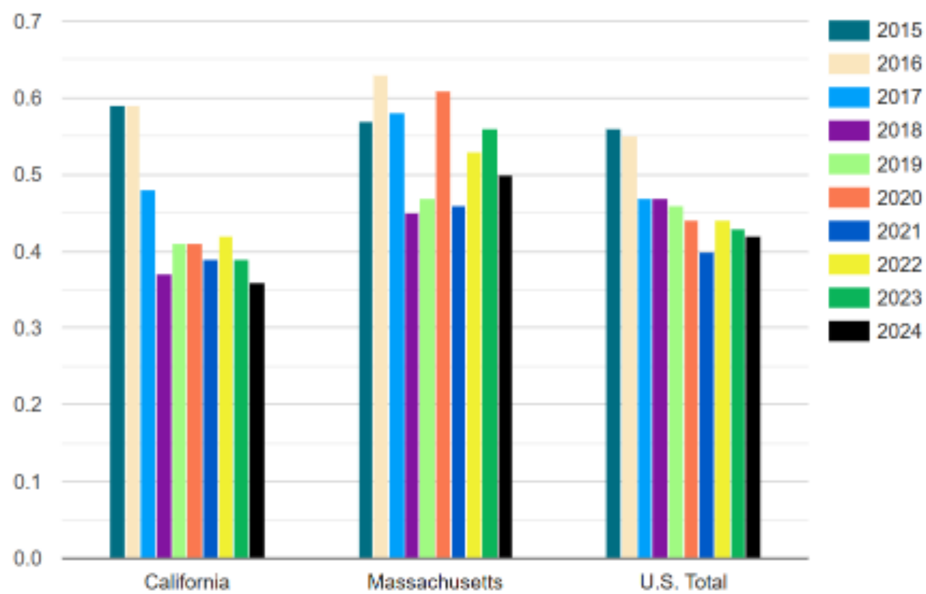
Narrative Example

Here is an example of how you can use narrative to describe the trends presented in Figure 1: "Overall, the total number of closures and closures into an employment setting for both all individuals and for individuals with IDD has declined steadily since 2015. There was also a decline of 4,462 individuals with IDD closed into employment with supported employment as a goal."

Graph Example

Figure 2 is an example of how graphs can be used to compare VR employment outcomes across states and the nation. The bar chart compares the rehabilitation rates of people with ID reported by Massachusetts, California, and the US during the years 2015–2024.

Figure 2. Example RSA-911 Bar Chart: Rehabilitation Rate of People with ID



Source: StateData

EXAMPLE 2: AMERICAN COMMUNITY SURVEY

Table Example

Here is an example of how data from the American Community Survey can be used to compare the employment rates of people with cognitive disabilities with the overall population in the US, over time. Figure 3 shows the estimated working-age population, the corresponding figure of people with any disability, and the corresponding figure of people with cognitive disabilities. Moreover, the table shows the numbers and the percentages of people in these three groups who reported employment. Data refer to the period 2015–2022, nationally.

Figure 3. Example ACS Table: Employment Participation for Working-Age People (Ages 16–64)

	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022
Number of people with no disability	184,004,153	183,851,796	185,323,522	185,614,965	184,902,918	184,371,875	185,475,926	185,671,823
Number of people with any disability	20,922,729	21,355,284	20,945,431	20,651,666	20,818,074	21,351,034	21,984,124	22,611,965
Number of people with a cognitive disability	9,109,557	9,323,212	9,191,844	9,164,490	9,471,017	9,800,833	10,191,687	10,856,049
Number of people with no disability who are employed	135,478,850	136,692,073	138,662,437	140,102,405	141,063,696	135,489,922	137,892,357	142,362,461
Number of people with any disability who are employed	7,168,137	7,552,149	7,600,545	7,622,666	7,962,441	8,042,478	8,792,398	9,891,187
Number of people with a cognitive disability who are employed	2,261,699	2,399,900	2,491,292	2,550,776	2,822,505	2,914,647	3,337,165	4,119,275
Percentage of people with no disability who are employed	73.6%	74.3%	74.8%	75.5%	76.3%	73.5%	74.3%	76.7%
Percentage of people with any disability who are employed	34.3%	35.4%	36.3%	36.9%	38.2%	37.7%	40.0%	43.7%
Percentage of people with a cognitive disability who are employed	24.8%	25.7%	27.1%	27.8%	29.8%	29.7%	32.7%	37.9%

Source: American Community Survey (ACS), Winsor et al., 2025, page 6

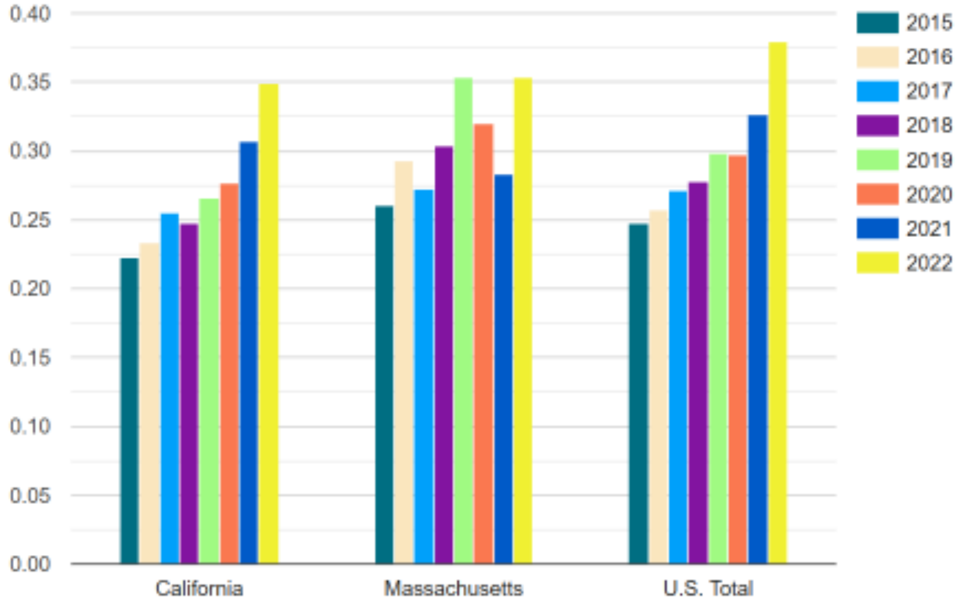
Narrative Example

Here is an example of how you can use narrative to describe the trends presented in Figure 3: "Overall, the estimated working-age population has increased slightly since 2015 , including the number of individuals with cognitive disabilities. Additionally, the percentage of people with a cognitive disability who are employed has increased from 24.8% in 2015 to 37.9% in 2022."

Graph Example

Here is an example of how a graph can be used to visualize and compare employment outcomes across states, based on data from the American Community Survey. The bar chart in Figure 4 compares the employment rates of people with cognitive disabilities ages 16 to 64 across two states (Massachusetts and California) and the US, for the period 2015–2022.

Figure 4. Example ACS Bar Chart: Employment Rate of People with Cognitive Disabilities



Source: [StateData]

EXAMPLE 3: NATIONAL SURVEY OF STATE INTELLECTUAL AND DEVELOPMENTAL DISABILITIES AGENCIES DAY AND EMPLOYMENT SERVICES

Table Example

This example shows how data from state IDD agencies can be used to explore the types of day services that adults with IDD receive, and how these data change over time, nationally. Specifically, Figure 5 shows the total number of people with IDD served each year over a period of eight years, the number and percentages of people who received services leading to integrated employment, and the percentages of people who received other services—including facility-based work, facility-based non- work, and community-based non-work. Finally, the table shows the number of people who were on waiting lists.

Figure 5. Example IDD Agency Table: Agency Outcomes by Employment Settings

	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022
Total number of people served	603,902	638,568	641,608	641,608	656,469	639,607	597,263	598,303
Number of people served in integrated employment	115,022	120,244	130,402	135,228	141,961	143,844	132,050	140,521
Percentage of people served in integrated employment	19.0%	18.8%	20.0%	21.7%	21.6%	22.5%	22.1%	23.5%
People served in integrated employment per 100K state population	35.2	37.2	40.1	41.4	43.2	42.8	39.6	42.2
Number of states reporting people in facility-based work	29	31	32	43	41	41	37	36
Percentage of people served in facility-based work	22.0%	16.0%	19.0%	14.7%	12.0%	11.8%	12.3%	11.9%
Number of people served in all non-work*	--	--	--	--	--	--	--	392,777
Percentage of people served in all non-work*	--	--	--	--	--	--	--	76.2%
Number of people served in facility-based non-work	37	36	38	41	40	39	40	33
Percentage of people served in facility-based non-work	53.0%	37.0%	51.9%	42.3%	42.1%	43.0%	41.8%	44.4%
Number of people served in community-based non-work	34	36	42	43	41	41	42	35
Percentage of people served in community-based non-work	43.0%	32.0%	40.1%	39.2%	44.0%	45.6%	43.3%	40.0%

Source: The National Survey of State Intellectual and Developmental Disability Agencies' Day and Employment Services, Winsor et al., 2025, page 7.

*facility-based and community-based.

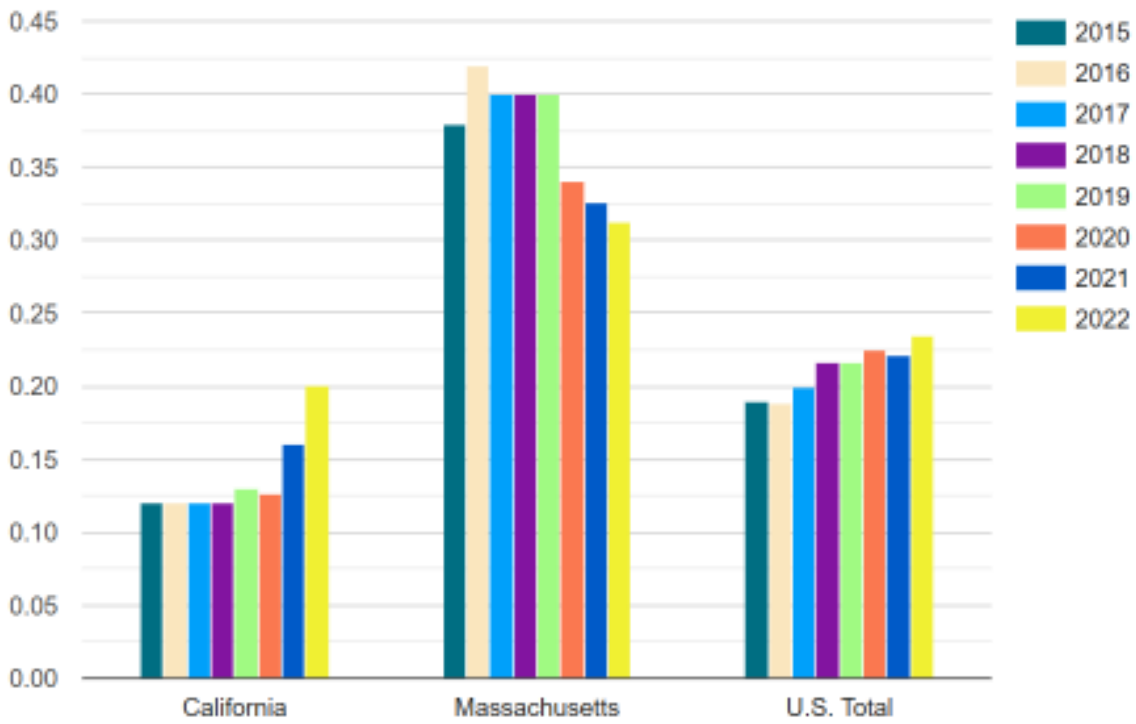
Narrative Example

Here is an example of how you can use narrative to describe the trends presented in Figure 5: "Overall, the estimated number of individuals served by state IDD agencies has increased between 2015 and 2019 when it reached 656,469, followed by a decrease to below 600,000 in 2022. The number of individuals served in integrated employment peaked at 143,844 and has declined to 140,521. The percentage of individuals served in integrated employment services has consistently increased, from 19% in 2015 to 23.5% in 2022."

Graph Example

Figure 6 shows On an example of a bar chart that helps visualize employment outcomes across states, based on data from state IDD agencies. Figure 6 shows the percentage of people with IDD who received integrated employment services in Massachusetts, compared to California, and the US, for the period 2015–2022.

Figure 6. Example IDD Agency Bar Chart: Percentage of People with IDD who Received Integrated Employment Services



Source: StateData

EXAMPLE 4: SOCIAL SECURITY ADMINISTRATION DATA

Table Example

This example shows how data from the Social Security Administration can be used to learn more about people with disabilities who receive Social Security benefits. Figure 7 shows how many people with disabilities received Social Security benefits, and how many of them worked during the years 2015–2022 nationally. Moreover, the table shows the number of people who received work incentives benefits, such as the Plan for Achieving Self-Support (PASS), Impairment-Related Work Expenses (IRWE), and Blind Work Expenses (BWE).

Figure 7. Example SSA Table: Employment and Work Incentive Program Participation for Supplemental Security Income (SSI) Beneficiaries

	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022
Total number of SSI recipients with disabilities	7,227,515	7,166,244	7,139,192	7,053,390	7,011,368	6,916,000	6,679,089	6,517,646
Number of SSI recipients with disabilities who are working	327,980	336,807	342,185	342,015	342,179	292,225	298,963	325,058
Percentage of SSI recipients with disabilities who are working	4.5%	4.7%	4.8%	4.8%	4.9%	4.2%	4.5%	4.9%
SSI recipients with disabilities who received Plans for Achieving Self-Support (PASS) benefits	821	692	635	568	480	401	323	270
SSI recipients with disabilities who received Impairment Related Work Expenses (IRWE) benefits	3,188	3,128	3,065	2,942	2,941	2,191	1,913	1,831
SSI recipients with disabilities who received Blind Work Expenses (BWE) benefits	1,161	1,068	1,022	955	876	653	576	568

Source: Social Security Administration, "SSI Disabled Recipients Who Work", Winsor et al., 2025, page 6

Narrative Example

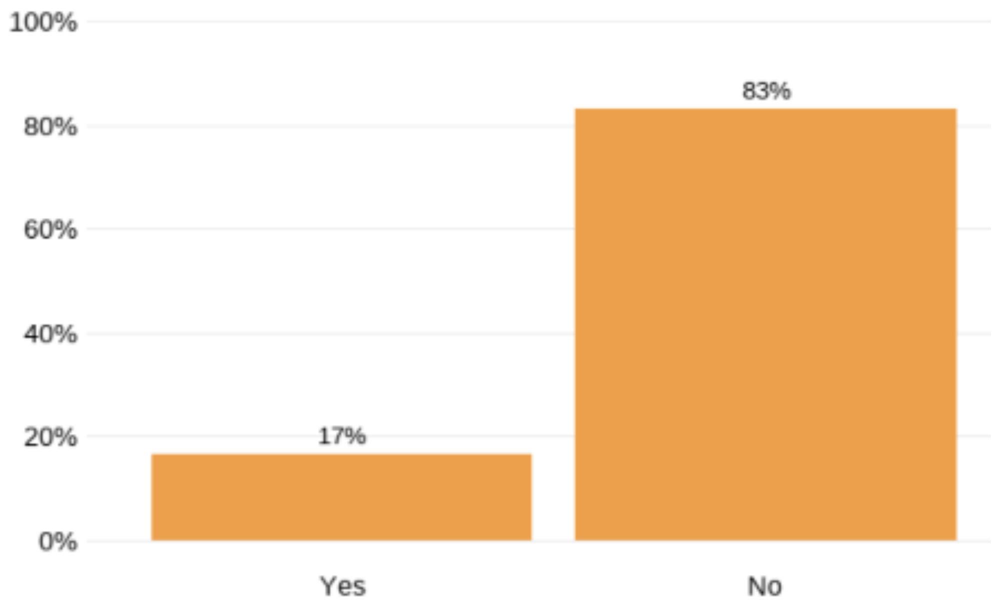
Here is an example of how you can use narrative to describe the trends presented in Figure 7: "Overall, the total number of Supplemental Security Income beneficiaries with disabilities has decreased steadily since 2015 . However, the number who are working has varied between 2015 and 2022. Additional data points of interest relate to the exceptionally low number of individuals who received Plans for Achieving Self-Support (PASS) benefits and Impairment-Related Work Expenses (IRWE) benefits. Further, there has been a marked decline in the number of individuals who received IRWE benefits since 2015."

EXAMPLE 5: NATIONAL CORE INDICATORS

Graph Example

This example shows how data from the National Core Indicators can be used to explore a variety of key variables including employment, rights, service planning, community inclusion, choice, and health and safety of adults who receive services from state IDD agencies. Specifically, Figure 8 shows the percentage of people with IDD who in 2023–2024 worked in community paid jobs, in the sample states that participated in the survey.

Figure 8. Example NCI Bar Chart: Percentage of People with IDD Who Have Paid Jobs (2023-2024)



Source: National Core Indicator, page 7

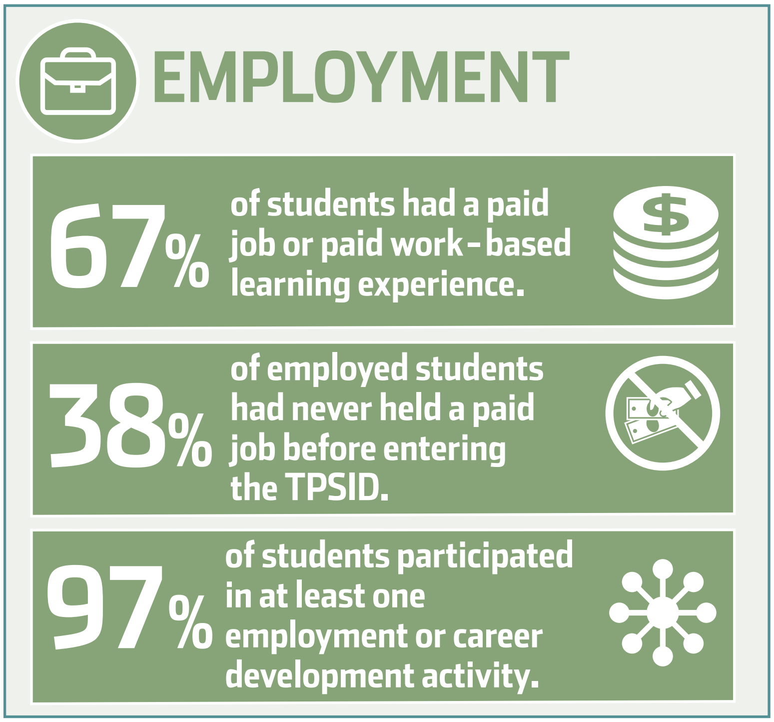
Narrative Example

Here is an example of how you can use narrative to describe the trends presented in Figure 8: "Data from the NCI Project demonstrate that during the data reporting period 2023–2024, only 17% of adults with IDD that were surveyed had jobs in the community."

EXAMPLE 6: TPSID DATA

The infographic in Figure 9 shows how data from the TPSID can be used to explore the employment experiences of students with disabilities in higher education participating in the Transition and Postsecondary Programs for Students with Intellectual Disabilities (TPSID). For example, Figure 9 shows that 67% of students with ID had paid jobs or paid work-based learning experiences, whereas 97% of students participated in at least one employment or career development activity in 2023–2024.

Figure 9. Example of TPSID Infographic: Percentage of Students Participating in Employment (2023-2024)



Source: Grigal et al., 2025 , page 1

Conclusion

Data on supports for people with disabilities can be used for many purposes, including analyzing the impact of policies, monitoring supports and services, providing a basis for quality improvement, helping establish the parameters of best practices, and as indicators of systems change (Bonardi et al., 2019).

Employment data can be important from both a strategic and program planning point of view, as it informs and promotes conversation about employment among key partners.

Data should be used to establish priorities and goals, and to support decision-making at multiple levels. It is the intent of this toolkit to provide guidance on how to use currently available national and state-level aggregate datasets to weave together a picture of the employment outcomes of adults with IDD and the return on investment of human service systems. This picture in turn can be used to inform future systems change activities.

References

Bonardi, A., Lauer, E., Lulinski, A., Fay, M. L., Morris, A., Nygren, M. A., & Krahn, G. (2019). Unlocking the potential of state level data: Opportunities to monitor health and related outcomes in people with intellectual and developmental disabilities. Intellectual and Developmental Disabilities, 57(5), 390–404.

Grigal, M., Papay, C., Bukaty, C., Choiseul-Praslin, B., Weir, C. &, Lazo, R. (2025). Highlights of the annual report of the Cohort 3 TPSID Model Demonstration Projects (Year 4, 2023–2024). University of Massachusetts Boston, Institute for Community Inclusion https://thinkcollege.net/sites/default/files/2025-05/Resources/23-24_Highlights_2025_R.pdf

Human Services Research Institute 2025 NCI-IDDTM In-Person Survey 2023-24 Data at a Glance. https://idd.nationalcoreindicators.org/wp-content/uploads/2025/07/NCI-IDD-IPS-2023-24-At-a-Glance.pdf

Individuals with disabilities* Education Improvement Act Amendments of 2004. (2004). Pub. L. No. 108– 446, FIR 1350, 108th Congress.

Mank, D., Cioffi, A., & Yovanoff, P. (2003). Supported employment outcomes across a decade: Is there evidence of improvement in the quality of implementation? Mental Retardation, 41(3), 188–197.

National Core Indicator (2022) National Report 2021-22 Overview and Methodology. https://idd.nationalcoreindicators.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/05/IPS-21-22-NCI-IDD-Overview-and-Methodology_FINAL5_12.pdf

National Core Indicators. (2017). Using National Core Indicators (NCI) data for quality improvement initiatives. National Association of State Directors of Developmental Disabilities Services and Human Services Research Institute. https://legacy.nationalcoreindicators.org/upload/core-indicators/using_data_cleanedDLH_%28003%29_3_22_18.pdf

National Core Indicators. (2012, April). Using National Core Indicators (NCI) data for quality improvement initiatives. National Association of State Directors of Developmental Disabilities Services and Human Services Research Institute. http://www.nationalcoreindicators.org

Stapleton & Thornton. (2009). Is it time to establish a national disability data collection system? Disability Policy Research Brief 9-3. Center for Studying Disability Policy, Mathematica Research Inc.

StateData.info: National data collection on day and employment services for individuals with developmental disabilities. (n.d.). https://www.thinkwork.org/statedata

Winsor, J., Shepard, J., Zalewska, A., Domin, D., Migliore, A., Wedeking, R., White, A. & Butterworth, J. (2025). State Data: The national report on employment services and outcomes through 2022. University of Massachusetts Boston, Institute for Community Inclusion.

This publication was produced by ThinkWork! and the State Employment Leadership Network (SELN) at the Institute for Community Inclusion (ICI) at UMass Boston.

ThinkWork! is a resource portal offering data, personal stories, and tools related to improving employment outcomes for people with intellectual and developmental disabilities.

The **SELN** is a place for states to connect, collaborate, and create cross-community support to advance employment of people with developmental disabilities. ICI and NASDDDS co-lead the SELN including the national project team and member states.
For more information visit: www.selnhub.org.

SUGGESTED CITATION:
Winsor, J., Freeze, S., Migliore, A., (2026) A Guide to Navigating Employment and Disability Data. Institute for Community Inclusion, University of Massachusetts Boston.

FOR MORE INFORMATION, CONTACT:
Jean Winsor, PhD
Jean.Winsor@umb.edu
Institute for Community Inclusion/UMass Boston

FUNDING SOURCE
The development of this product was supported in part by the Administration on Disabilities, Administration for Community Living, US Department of Health and Human Services, under cooperative agreement #90DNPA0007, and the State Employment Leadership Network (SELN). The contents of this publication do not necessarily represent the policy of HHS, and you should not assume endorsement by the Federal Government.

State Employment Leadership Network

NASDDDS
National Association of State Directors of Developmental Disabilities Services

ICI ThinkWork!
INSTITUTE FOR COMMUNITY INCLUSION, UMASS BOSTON